Lesson 2

Addictions

"A man is a slave to whatever has mastered him."
(2 Peter 2:19)

Addiction: being physically or psychologically enslaved to a mood altering habit or practice

Addictions come in many varieties. Our society is riddled with: alcoholism, illicit drugs, prescription drug abuse, gambling, sexual addiction, pornography, cigarette smoking, and food addiction. All of these addictions share one thing in common—they bring temporary pleasure at the expense of long-term harmful consequences.

Synopsis

Alcoholism: People who drink too much alcohol often ruin their own lives and the lives of those around them; their world is full of strife and sorrow.[1] When a person drinks alcohol, it can go down smoothly at first, but in the end it "bites like a snake and poisons like a viper."[2] Getting drunk leads to a life focused on sensual pleasure (debauchery).[3]

Who has woe? Who has sorrow? Who has strife? Who has complaints? Who has needless bruises? Who has bloodshot eyes? Those who linger over wine, who go to sample bowls of mixed wine.
(Proverbs 23: 29-30)[1]

Do not gaze at wine when it is red, when it sparkles in the cup, when it goes down smoothly! In the end it bites like a snake and poisons like a viper.
(Proverbs 23: 31-32)[2]

Do not get drunk on wine, which leads to debauchery. Instead, be filled with the Spirit.
(Ephesians 5:18)[3]

16 Addictions

People who drink alcohol often brag about how much they can drink.[4] They stay up late drinking and then when they wake up they want to drink again.[5] They ridicule others (mock them) and often get into fights.[6] In the end, alcohol consumption can lead to a life of poverty.[7] Most importantly, people who live a lifestyle of drunkenness and lasciviousness place themselves in danger of losing the biggest prize of all—the kingdom of God.[8]

Gluttony: For people who eat too much, their "god" is their stomach; they have their minds set on earthly things.[9] Like the drunkard, gluttons often end up becoming poor because of their overindulgence.[10] The Bible warns us that a companion of gluttons "disgraces his father."[11]

Woe to those who are heroes at drinking wine
and champions at mixing drinks.
(Isaiah 5:22)[4]

Woe to those who rise early in the morning to run after their drinks, who stay up late at night till they are inflamed with wine.
(Isaiah 5:11)[5]

Wine is a mocker and beer a brawler;
whoever is led astray by them is not wise.
(Proverbs 20:1)[6]

He who loves pleasure will become poor;
whoever loves wine and oil will never be rich.
(Proverbs 21:17)[7]

The acts of the sinful nature are obvious: sexual immorality, impurity and debauchery; idolatry and witchcraft; hatred, discord, jealousy, fits of rage, selfish ambition, dissensions, factions and envy; drunkenness, orgies, and the like. I warn you, as I did before, that those who live like this will not inherit the kingdom of God.
(Galatians 5:19-21)[8]

Their destiny is destruction, their god is their stomach, and their glory is in their shame. Their mind is on earthly things.
(Philippians 3:19)[9]

Do not join those who drink too much wine or gorge themselves on meat, for drunkards and gluttons become poor, and drowsiness clothes them in rags.
(Proverbs 23:20-21)[10]

Drug Addiction: Drug addicts abuse their bodies. Such abuse is offensive to God, because our bodies are God's temple and the Holy Spirit lives in us.[12,13] Any one who destroys God's sacred temple, God will destroy him.[13]

Drug addicts are slaves to their drugs and controlled by their sinful nature.[14,15] Living according to the sinful nature leads to death, but living according to the Spirit leads to life. Those who live by the sinful nature cannot please God.[16,17] God wants us to purify ourselves from everything that contaminates the body and spirit, "perfecting holiness out of reverence for God."[18]

Sexual Addiction: People who are sexually addicted have a craving for more and more sex, often in increasingly perverted ways.

He who keeps the law is a discerning son, but a companion of gluttons disgraces his father.
(Proverbs 28:7)[11]

For we are the temple of the living God.
(2 Corinthians 6:16)[12]

Don't you know that you yourselves are God's temple and that God's Spirit lives in you? If anyone destroys God's temple, God will destroy him; for God's temple is sacred, and you are that temple.
(1 Corinthians 3:16-17)[13]

A man is a slave to whatever has mastered him.
(2 Peter 2:19)[14]

Everyone who sins is a slave to sin. Now a slave has no permanent place in the family, but a son belongs to it forever.
(John 8:34-35)[15]

Those controlled by the sinful nature cannot please God.
(Romans 8:8)[16]

For if you live according to the sinful nature, you will die; but if by the Spirit you put to death the misdeeds of the body, you will live, because those who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God.
(Romans 8:13-14)[17]

Let us purify ourselves from everything that contaminates body and spirit, perfecting holiness out of reverence for God.
(2 Corinthians 7:1)[18]

18 Addictions

The men and women of Sodom and Gomorrah and ancient Rome became preoccupied with sex, with a continual lust for more.[19,20] Both these civilizations perished.

As Christians, we are to abstain from sexual immorality; all other sins a man commits are outside his body, but he who sins sexually sins against his own body.[21] We are to learn to control our bodies in a way that is holy and honorable, not in passionate lust like the people who do not know God.[22]

We are to "put to death" sexual immorality and impurity and everything that belongs to our earthly nature.[23] We are to get rid of all moral filth.[24] Your body is a "temple of the Holy Spirit," who is in you, and which you have received from God. Therefore, you can't

Sodom and Gomorrah and the surrounding towns gave themselves up to sexual immorality and perversion. They serve as an example of those who suffer the punishment of eternal fire.
(Jude 1:7)[19]

Having lost all sensitivity, they have given themselves over to sensuality so as to indulge in every kind of impurity, with a continual lust for more.
(Ephesians 4:19)[20]

Flee from sexual immorality. All other sins a man commits are outside his body, but he who sins sexually sins against his own body.
(1 Corinthians 6:18)[21]

It is God's will that you should be sanctified: that you should avoid sexual immorality; that each of you should learn to control his own body in a way that is holy and honorable, not in passionate lust like the heathen, who do not know God; and that in this matter no one should wrong his brother or take advantage of him.
(1 Thessalonians 4:3-5)[22]

Put to death, therefore, whatever belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry.
(Colossians 3:5)[23]

Therefore, get rid of all moral filth and the evil that is so prevalent and humbly accept the word planted in you.
(James 1:21)[24]

just do whatever you want to do with your body. It was bought for a price—Christ's death on the cross. Therefore, you are to honor God with your body.[25]

People with sexual addictions often take advantage of other people to meet their desires; this runs contrary to God's teaching. We should treat others with "absolute purity,"[26] without even a hint of sexual immorality.[27] God has a dire warning for those who live a lifestyle of unrepentant sexual sin—they will not inherit the kingdom of God.[28]

Gambling Addiction: The Bible warns us to keep ourselves free of the love of money and to be content with what we have.[29] People who want to get rich quickly get trapped in their sin and do many foolish and harmful things that end up in "ruin and destruction."[30] The love of money is the root of all kinds of evil.[31]

Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore honor God with your body.
(1 Corinthians 6:19-20)[25]

Treat younger men as brothers, older women as mothers, and younger women as sisters, with absolute purity.
(1 Timothy 5:1-2)[26]

But among you there must not be even a hint of sexual immorality, or of any kind of impurity, or of greed, because these are improper for God's holy people.
(Ephesians 5:3)[27]

Do you not know that the wicked will not inherit the kingdom of God? Do not be deceived: Neither the sexually immoral nor idolaters nor adulterers nor male prostitutes nor homosexual offenders nor thieves nor the greedy nor drunkards nor slanderers nor swindlers will inherit the kingdom of God.
(1 Corinthians 6:9-11)[28]

Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have.
(Hebrews 13:5)[29]

People who want to get rich fall into temptation and a trap and into many foolish and harmful desires that plunge men into ruin and destruction.
(1 Timothy 6:9)[30]

20 Addictions

People who love money never seem to have enough.[32] People who gamble want to "get rich quick," but the Bible warns us not to wear ourselves out trying to get rich.[33] The person who chases fantasies of being wealthy will end up with "his fill of poverty,"[34] and anyone eager to get rich "will not go unpunished."[35]

God's Guidance

People who are "hooked" on the short-term pleasure of addictions find it extremely difficult to break their habits. They become slaves to their sin.[36,37] Time after time they have tried to resist, but time after time they have given in to temptation.[38-40] Only God offers an effective "way out" of addictions.

For the love of money is the root of all kinds of evil.
(1 Timothy 6:10)[31]

Whoever loves money never has money enough.
(Ecclesiastes 5:10)[32]

Do not wear yourselves out trying to get rich; have the wisdom to show restraint.
(Proverbs 23:4)[33]

He who works his land will have abundant food, but the one who chases fantasies will have his fill of poverty.
(Proverbs 28:19)[34]

A faithful man will be richly blessed, but one eager to get rich will not go unpunished.
(Proverbs 28:20)[35]

A man is a slave to whatever has mastered him.
(2 Peter 2:19)[36]

I tell you the truth, everyone who sins is a slave to sin.
(John 8:34)[37]

I do not understand what I do. For what I want to do I do not do, but what I hate I do.
(Romans 7:15)[38]

For what I do is not the good I want to do; no, the evil I do not want to do—this I keep on doing.
(Romans 7:19)[39]

All addictions represent a battle between what the flesh wants and what the spirit desires.[41] The first step in overcoming addictions is to recognize that you cannot control your addiction on your own—you need God's help. Remember that God will never let you be tempted beyond what you can bear,[42] and when you are tempted He will always provide a way out, so that you can "stand up" under the temptation.[43]

If you are addicted, turn to God.[44] If you confess with your mouth "Jesus is Lord," and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will receive eternal salvation.[45] You will become an entirely new creation and will be "born again," and filled with the

I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my sinful nature. For I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out.
(Romans 7:18)[40]

So I say, live by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the sinful nature. For the sinful nature desires what is contrary to the spirit, and the spirit what is contrary to the sinful nature.
(Galatians 5:16-17)[41]

And God is faithful; he will not let you be tempted beyond what you can bear.
(1 Corinthians 10:13)[42]

But when you are tempted, he will also provide a way out so that you can stand up under it.
(1 Corinthians 10:13)[43]

What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death? Thanks be to God—through Jesus Christ our Lord!
(Romans 7:24-25)[44]

That if you confess with your mouth, "Jesus is Lord," and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.
(Romans 10:9)[45]

22 Addictions

Holy Spirit, the great Counselor.[46] You will no longer be controlled by the sinful nature, but by the Spirit of God, who lives in you.[47,48]

Live one day at a time, and pray each day that God will take away your sinful desire.[49] Completely abandon yourself to God, and seek His will for your life.[50] Fix your eyes on Jesus, the author and perfector of our faith.[51] "Clothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ," and stop thinking about how to gratify the desires of your addiction.[52]

In humility, regularly confess your sins to God,[53] and to your fellow man.[54] Seek out anyone you may have harmed because of your

But the Counselor, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have said to you.
(John 14:26)[46]

You, however, are controlled not by the sinful nature but by the Spirit, if the Spirit of God lives in you.
(Romans 8:9)[47]

For if you live according to the sinful nature, you will die; but if by the spirit you put to death the misdeeds of the body, you will live, because those who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God.
(Romans 8:13-14)[48]

I tell you the truth, my father will give you anything you ask in my name.
(John 16:23)[49]

The world and its desires pass away, but the man who does the will of God lives forever.
(1 John 2:17)[50]

Let us fix our eyes on Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith.
(Hebrews 12:2)[51]

Clothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ, and do not think about how to gratify the desires of the sinful nature.
(Romans 13:14)[52]

If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness.
(1 John 1:9)[53]

addiction and ask for forgiveness. Forgive yourself also, for we are all sinners and have fallen short of the glory of God.[55] Remember, God showed his love for us by this: "While were still sinners, Christ died for us."[56]

Always have hope.[57] Even though you are not strong enough to conquer your addiction by yourself, with God's help you can.[58] And if the Son of God sets you free, "you will be free indeed."[59]

Finally, once God has delivered you from your addiction, go and tell others who may also be suffering,[60] so that they too may have hope and come to a knowledge of God's mighty power and authority over sin.

Confess your sins to each other and pray for each other
so that you may be healed.
(James 5:16)[54]

For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.
(Romans 3:23)[55]

But God demonstrates his own love for us in this:
While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.
(Romans 5:8)[56]

Anyone who is among the living has hope.
(Ecclesiastes 9:4)[57]

Jesus looked at them and said, *"With man this is impossible,
but with God all things are possible."*
(Matthew 19:26)[58]

So if the Son sets you free,
you will be free indeed.
(John 8:36)[59]

Blessed are those who have learned to acclaim you,
who walk in the light of your presence, O LORD.
(Psalm 89:15)[60]